

The Sandglass Court

Licensed classic · labyrinth edition

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Bell Beneath the Stairs

Most people thought the Library Labyrinth slept at night. The front halls dimmed, the borrowing desk lights softened to honey-gold, and the ordinary shelves stood quietly like patient trees.

Lior knew better.

At exactly nine breaths past midnight, the stone floor under the Atlas Wing gave a low metallic hum, then shifted one handspan to the left. A narrow stair appeared where no stair had been before, curling down in a tight spiral. And from far below, muffled by thick walls and old magic, came the slow toll of a bell made from bronze and moonglass.

Three chimes meant one thing.

Court.

Lior tugged his apprentice sash straight, pressed his ink-stained palms against his trousers, and hurried down the spiral steps two at a time. He was apprenticed to the Judge of Overdue Moments, which sounded grand when people said it aloud and mostly meant he carried stacks of lawbooks, fetched tea, and copied legal phrases that took half a page to say what could have been said in one line.

Still, on nights like this, even copying felt important.

The stair opened into the Pendulum Atrium, a circular chamber carved into the heart of the labyrinth. Enormous clocks hung from chains along the walls. Some ran fast, some slow, some backward, and one in the corner insisted, with tremendous confidence, that it was always Thursday.

At the center stood the Sandglass Court itself: a crescent of stone benches around a raised dais, where the Judge's chair waited beneath a canopy of tiny swinging hourglasses. Above everything turned the Great Pendulum, long as a ship's mast, sweeping left-right-left with a whisper that sounded like pages turning.

"You're late by twenty-seven heartbeats," said Tamsin, without looking up.

Tamsin was the hourglass clerk, keeper of filings, ledgers, timing seals, and exactly four thousand, six hundred, and two tiny glass measures arranged in labeled drawers. She wore fingerless gloves dusted with silver sand and spectacles that flashed blue when she was annoyed. At the moment, they were flashing very blue.

"I ran," Lior said.

"You also tripped on the second stair, recovered on the fourth, and forgot your quill case."

Lior blinked. "How do you know that?"

Tamsin held up his quill case. "Because I found this on the second stair. And because listening is seventy percent of my job."

Before he could answer, the side doors opened with a low groan, and two bailiffs entered. Between them walked a figure wrapped in twilight-colored cloth, hands unbound but glowing faintly at the wrists where temporary oath-threads shimmered.

The figure lifted their chin. Their eyes were bright ember-gold, old and young at once.

Lior recognized them from whispered stories told in reading nooks.

Ashling. A story-spirit.

The bell rang once more. Judge Maren Vale stepped onto the dais, robe hem stitched with tiny silver clocks, and the entire chamber rose.

"This court now sits," the Judge said, voice calm as still water. "Bring the charge."

Chapter 2 — The Law of Borrowed Minutes

Lior had seen hearings about borrowed afternoons, misplaced anniversaries, and one very noisy dispute over a missing Tuesday. He had never seen the gallery this full.

Caretakers from the nursery wing sat beside grandfathers in wool coats. Two librarians from the Dream Index took notes with furious speed. A whole cluster of children in moon-print pajamas occupied the back row with mugs of warm milk, eyes wide enough to reflect the lanterns.

They all smelled faintly of bedtime.

Tamsin stood at the clerk's lectern and unrolled a parchment strip that seemed to keep unrolling no matter how much wood it crossed. She cleared her throat.

"Case Seven-Seven-Nine-B. The Labyrinth v. Ashling of the Seventh Tale Current." She glanced toward the defendant. "Charge: unauthorized extraction and retention of five minutes from registered bedtime stories, repeated over one hundred and ninety-two nights, in violation of the Custodial Time Code, Sections Eleven through Fourteen."

A rustle swept the room like wind through paper.

Five minutes.

From every bedtime story.

Lior felt his stomach tighten. In the upper halls, he'd noticed children coming to morning reading circles with shadows under their eyes, saying things like, "The story ended too fast," or "I wasn't sleepy yet." He had assumed it was exam season or sugar sneaking. Now he wondered.

Judge Vale folded her hands. "How does the defendant plead?"

Ashling stepped forward. Their voice was low and clear, carrying to every bench without effort.

"I took the minutes," Ashling said. "So to the act itself, guilty."

Gasps.

Ashling continued before anyone could interrupt. "But not to theft in spirit or intent."

Judge Vale's expression did not change. "This court recognizes complex pleas. We proceed to full hearing."

Lior scribbled notes while trying not to stare. Story-spirits were rare even in the labyrinth, beings woven from telling and listening, made strong by repeated retellings. Ashling's cloak shifted in faint patterns like moving text. Every time they breathed, the nearest lantern flame bent toward them.

Tamsin lifted a small hammer and struck the hourglass seal embedded in the lectern. Sand flowed upward instead of down.

"By the Measure and the Memory," she intoned, "truth is timed and timing is truth."

The Judge nodded. "Prosecution, your opening."

Master Quill, advocate for the Labyrinth Registry, stood. His beard looked like it had been organized by ruler and compass. "Your Honor, the law is plain. Bedtime minutes are held in trust for children, families, and communal rest. They are not private currency. The defendant removed those minutes without petition, without notice, and without consent."

He lifted a stack of complaint cards bound with red thread.

"As a result: fractured sleep, unfinished soothing rituals, and distress in households across six wings."

Ashling watched without flinching.

Lior dipped his quill again, blotting twice because his hand had started to shake.

Judge Vale turned to the defense table, where no advocate sat.

"Ashling, do you represent yourself?"

"I do."

"Then prepare to answer evidence with evidence."

Ashling bowed once. "I came to do exactly that."

Above them, the Great Pendulum swung. The gallery held its breath.

And in the measured hush between one swing and the next, Lior had the oddest feeling that the case was not at all what it seemed.

Chapter 3 — The Five-Minute Wound

Evidence in Sandglass Court was never only paper.

When Master Quill called the first witness, Tamsin slid open Drawer 88-A and withdrew a thumb-sized hourglass stoppered with green wax. She set it into a copper cradle at the center of the floor. At once, a translucent scene bloomed over the cradle like mist catching moonlight.

A bedroom appeared: quilt with dinosaurs, lamp shaped like a pear, one tired father reading from a picture book. His voice reached the final page, and then—snap. The ending folded shut too quickly. The child sat up, confused.

"But where did the fox sleep?" the child asked.

"That's... that's all that was there tonight," the father said, sounding embarrassed. "Try to rest anyway."

The scene dissolved.

Then another: grandmother, twins, lullaby-book. Again the last stretch vanished. Again uncertainty.

A third: big sister reading to little brother. He frowned, no longer drowsy, and asked to start over from page one.

Master Quill paced slowly.

"One household can adapt. Ten can adapt. Two hundred lose rhythm. Bedtime depends on closure. Closure depends on those final minutes."

He raised both hands, and Tamsin, expression tight, released six more witness-hourglasses in sequence. Each showed the same pattern: stories clipped before the settling moment, children alert when they should have drifted, caretakers improvising endings with tired voices and anxious smiles.

Lior's chest ached watching them. He remembered his own mother, years ago, tracing circles on his wrist as she told him about a boat made of moonwood. He had always fallen asleep in the same place: right after the gentle ending where everyone came home.

Master Quill faced the Judge.

"No one denies the defendant's nature as a story-spirit. But nature does not excuse harm. Ashling acted unilaterally, repeatedly, and with full awareness."

Judge Vale inclined her head. "Defense response."

Ashling stepped to the center, just where the witness scenes had glowed.

"Those moments are real," they said softly. "The harm is real. I do not dispute it."

The room shifted with surprise. Even Master Quill blinked.

"Then what remains to argue?" he demanded.

Ashling's ember-gold eyes moved across the gallery: the worried adults, the pajama-clad children, the librarians, Lior with ink on his fingers and questions in his throat.

"Reason," Ashling said.

Judge Vale leaned forward. "Reason is not absolution."

"No," Ashling agreed. "But it is context, and context is the difference between a thief and someone making a terrible, desperate choice."

Tamsin's quill paused above her ledger.

Judge Vale tapped the arm of her chair once, thoughtful.

"You will have your chance to present context. First, cross-examination."

Lior watched as Ashling questioned the witnesses with startling gentleness.

To one father: "When the ending vanished, did your daughter cry?" "No. She asked questions."

To a librarian: "Did children stop coming to story circles?" "No. They came more."

To a caretaker: "Did families read together less?" "No. More. But everyone was tired."

Not denial, Lior realized. Mapping.

By the time cross-examination ended, the harm remained clear—yet the shape of it had changed. Not simple damage. Something tangled.

Judge Vale struck the bench bell lightly.

"Court recess. Twenty minutes."

As everyone rose in murmuring knots, Lior looked toward Ashling. The story-spirit stood alone beside the defense table, shoulders set as if bracing against weather.

And for the first time, Lior wondered not "How could they?" but "What could drive them?"

Chapter 4 — Apprentices Ask Dangerous Questions

Recess meant tea for the Judge, filing stamps for Tamsin, and for Lior, usually, silent copying in the clerk alcove. Tonight he lingered by the shelves of procedural manuals, pretending to sort index tabs while listening to the room reset itself. Bailiffs chatted near the north door. The gallery stretched. Someone unwrapped mint candies with astonishingly loud paper.

Tamsin appeared at his elbow carrying three ledgers and a look that could pin butterflies.

"You're hovering," she said.

"I'm thinking."

"In this court those are often the same thing."

Lior lowered his voice. "Doesn't something feel... incomplete?"

Tamsin set down the ledgers in perfect alignment. "In what way?"

"Ashling admitted taking the minutes, and the evidence is strong. But if it were simple theft, why plead this way? Why not deny intent and hide behind ambiguity?"

Tamsin adjusted her spectacles. "Because they are either honest or strategic."

"Could be both."

She studied him, then sighed the sigh of someone rearranging their own certainty by one shelf.

"I logged extraction patterns," she said. "I had to. It's my duty. They were precise: five minutes from every registered bedtime story, no more, no less. Always the last segment. Never touching emergency calming scripts, never touching medical rest protocols, never touching stories for infants under two."

Lior stared.

"That sounds... selective."

"It is selective." Tamsin's voice sharpened. "And still illegal."

He nodded. "Right. Of course. But selective for what?"

Before she answered, a soft voice came from behind them.

"To avoid greater harm where I could."

Ashling stood in the alcove entrance, oath-threads dimmer now but still visible at their wrists. A bailiff hovered several steps back, watchful.

Lior went rigid. "I— I didn't realize—"

"You were whispering under a shelf of brass manuals," Ashling said, almost amused. "Everyone realized."

Tamsin crossed her arms. "Defendants are discouraged from wandering clerk spaces."

"I asked permission. Your bailiff gave it." Ashling inclined their head. "I wanted water. I also wanted to say this: your observations are accurate."

Lior swallowed. "About selectivity?"

"Yes. I chose where not to take minutes. That choice mattered to me."

Tamsin's jaw tightened. "If you understood impact enough to choose carefully, then you understood enough not to take anything."

Ashling met her gaze without flinching. "That is what makes desperation ugly."

Silence dropped between them, heavy as stone.

From the dais, Judge Vale's clerk bell rang twice: recess ending.

Ashling stepped back. "You will hear the rest soon."

They turned toward the chamber, then paused and looked at Lior.

"Apprentice," Ashling said, "when you copy law, do you copy margins too?"

"Sometimes," Lior said, baffled.

"Good. The margins are where people write what the rule forgot."

Then they were gone, escorted back to the floor.

Tamsin stared after them, then picked up her ledgers with quick, decisive motions.

"Do not romanticize this," she muttered. "Children lost sleep."

"I know."

"And law exists because feeling alone cannot carry a city."

Lior nodded again, but as he followed her out, Ashling's question echoed in his head.

What the rule forgot.

He had never thought of law as forgetful before.

Chapter 5 — The Ledger with a Missing Column

Proceedings resumed with the prosecution's final witness: the Registry Chronometrist, who confirmed extraction signatures matched Ashling's story-thread exactly. Sandprints, aura traces, cadence marks—every magical test aligned.

Then Judge Vale turned to the defense.

"Present your context."

Ashling placed both hands on the defense rail. Their voice, when it came, was steady but rough around the edges.

"I serve in the Seventh Tale Current, where unfinished stories drift until retold. Three months ago, my sibling Brindle fell ill with Fade Sickness."

The gallery stirred. Lior had heard of Fade Sickness only in archive notes: a condition that thinned story-spirits until their outlines blurred and their words slipped away.

Ashling continued. "The ailment steals narrative cohesion. A spirit loses sequence: beginning without middle, middle without end. He would wake and not remember his own name past the first syllable."

Tamsin, despite herself, lowered her quill.

"Treatment exists," Ashling said. "Rare, costly, and precise. It requires distilled Rest Minutes from active bedtime currents. Not dream hours. Not nap fragments. Bedtime minutes only: the stretch where fear settles and safety roots."

Master Quill rose sharply. "Then you should have filed petition Form 22-C for compassionate allocation."

"I did. Three times." Ashling lifted a folded packet tied in blue ribbon. "Denied twice for insufficient reserves. Third petition remained pending for thirty-one nights."

Tamsin's eyes narrowed. She accepted the packet from the bailiff, checked the seal, and carried it to the Judge.

Judge Vale scanned the first page, then the second. Her face did not move, but Lior saw her thumb pause on one line.

"Registry?" she asked.

Master Quill looked genuinely unsettled. "I... was not informed of these filings."

"Yet they bear your office crest."

"Then they were processed at assistant level."

Ashling's laugh was small and tired. "While my sibling unraveled."

Judge Vale raised one palm. "Order."

Ashling exhaled.

"I panicked. I broke the law. I took five minutes nightly because that amount could be hidden inside ordinary bedtime variation and because more would have caused deeper disruption. I stored every minute in sealed vials for treatment only. I kept records. I did not sell, trade, or consume a single measure."

Lior's pulse thudded in his ears. Around him, the gallery seemed split between anger and sorrow, both equally sharp.

Master Quill recovered enough to speak. "Compassion does not erase unauthorized taking."

"No," Ashling said. "It does not. I am here because I know that."

Judge Vale looked toward Tamsin. "Clerk. Verify filing history from court mirror archive."

Tamsin hesitated one heartbeat, then nodded. "At once."

She crossed to the archive pedestal and pressed both gloved hands to its rim. Glass lit from within. Columns of tiny script climbed into the air, spinning.

Lior watched her eyes track line after line.

Then he saw her go very still.

"Your Honor," Tamsin said quietly, "the filings are real."

A breath passed through the room like a single shared gasp.

"And," she added, voice tighter now, "the queue protocol appears to have omitted urgent medical markings for non-citizen story entities."

Master Quill closed his eyes briefly.

Lior felt a chill despite the warm lamps.

A missing column, he thought.

Not just Ashling's crime.

The system's gap.

Chapter 6 — Through the Labyrinth of Records

Judge Vale recessed again, this time not for tea.

"This court does not sentence while facts remain unstable," she said. "Clerk Tamsin, Apprentice Lior, with me to Record Vault Nine."

Master Quill objected, then stopped when the Judge looked at him.

"You will remain available," she said. "Bring your deputy and every queue policy enacted in the last five years."

Vault Nine sat beneath the court, beyond a corridor of locked doors each marked with a date and a warning. The air smelled of cedar, ink, and cooling metal. Shelves rose six stories high, carrying crystal tablets, bound ledgers, and rolled protocols tied in different ribbon colors according to urgency.

Tamsin moved like lightning between ladders, pulling files before Lior could finish reading their labels.

"Queue schema revisions, compassionate allocation guidelines, cross-entity triage..." She shoved a stack into his arms. "Don't drop those. If they shatter, we'll spend a week apologizing to timestamps."

Judge Vale sat at the central table and began reading at astonishing speed.

Hours seemed to fold inward.

At one point Lior climbed a ladder to retrieve the amendment index and noticed something odd: a ribbon seal on one binder had been snipped and retied crookedly, the knot wrong for registry staff. He pointed it out.

Tamsin took the binder, brows knitting. "This is Supplement K, priority normalization."

She flipped pages, then froze.

"Here," she said, tapping a paragraph. "'Non-citizen narrative entities to be routed through secondary review due to verification complexity.'"

Judge Vale held out her hand.

Tamsin passed the binder over. "Secondary review adds minimum twenty-one nights."

"For urgent medical petitions?" Lior asked.

"For all petitions in that category," Tamsin replied.

Judge Vale read the signature line, expression turning colder by the second.

"Unsigned amendment. Illegally inserted."

Lior's mouth went dry. "So Ashling's petitions were delayed by a rule that shouldn't exist?"

"Yes," said the Judge.

"Then if the lawful queue had run—"

"The first petition might have been approved in time," Tamsin finished.

Silence.

The pendulum from the chamber above thudded faintly through stone.

Judge Vale closed the binder carefully, as if it were fragile and dangerous both.

"We return to court."

Back in the chamber, the gallery rose as they entered, murmurs snapping shut into tense quiet.

Judge Vale resumed her seat.

"New evidence has been admitted," she announced. "An unauthorized policy insertion created systemic delay for non-citizen narrative entities, including the defendant's medical petitions."

Shock moved visibly across faces. Master Quill looked ill.

"This does not erase the defendant's unlawful extraction," the Judge continued, "but it establishes institutional contribution to the circumstances."

Ashling closed their eyes once, brief and exhausted.

Judge Vale turned to them. "Where are the stored minutes now?"

"In the Understack Infirmary, sealed by my oath and the healer's bond."

"For your sibling?"

"Yes."

The Judge nodded slowly.

"Then this court will inspect those vials before verdict."

Lior's pen flew over parchment. In all his months apprenticing, he had never seen the law bend to hold so many

truths at once.

Harm. Desperation. Failure. Intent.

The case was no longer a straight line.

It was a labyrinth.

Chapter 7 — Brindle in the Infirmary Light

The Understack Infirmary lay deep in the labyrinth where the walls hummed softly with stabilizing songs. Beds were shaped like open books, each with curved headboards carved into constellations. Lanterns hung low to keep shadows gentle.

Judge Vale, Tamsin, Lior, Master Quill, and two bailiffs arrived just before dawn's first bell.

Healer Sera met them in a coat stitched with tiny silver stitches that looked like mended cracks. "You're here for the Fade case."

Ashling stepped forward, suddenly less composed than in court. "How is he?"

Sera's expression softened. "Holding."

She led them to a bed screened by gauze curtains. Inside lay Brindle.

Lior had expected something dramatic—glow or smoke or obvious magical illness. Instead he saw a slight figure with hair like dark moss and hands curled under the blanket, as if guarding something precious in sleep. But the edges of Brindle's form flickered now and then, blurring like a smudged illustration.

Each flicker made Ashling flinch.

On a nearby tray stood twelve tiny vials of silver-blue sand, each labeled in careful script:

NIGHT 143 — 5 MINUTES NIGHT 144 — 5 MINUTES NIGHT 145 — 5 MINUTES

and so on.

Tamsin stepped close, reading labels with professional precision. "These are measured accurately," she said, almost to herself. "No adulteration."

Healer Sera nodded. "I monitored every transfer. The defendant brought only bedtime-rest fractions. Never more than needed for one stabilizing infusion."

Master Quill asked stiffly, "How many vials remain unspent?"

"Thirty-seven."

"Could they be returned?"

Sera considered. "Unspent ones, yes, with care. Spent treatment cannot be undone any more than swallowed medicine can."

Judge Vale watched Brindle's flickering outline for a long moment.

"Does treatment work?"

"Partially," Sera said. "Without it, he would have unraveled by now. With it, he's stable enough to recover if legal supply can be approved immediately."

Ashling's shoulders dropped, the smallest release of held terror.

Lior looked between siblings. He understood suddenly that every clipped bedtime in the city had been, for Ashling, one more night of buying time.

Wrongly bought.

Still bought.

Tamsin reached into her satchel and withdrew her ledger board. She hesitated, then spoke to the Judge.

"Your Honor, with permission, I can compute restitution paths that avoid harming current sleep schedules. If we spread returned minutes over twelve weeks and pair with voluntary story circles, families may regain closure without abrupt disruption."

Judge Vale gave a brief nod. "Do it."

Master Quill straightened, startled. "Clerk, that's not your assigned scope."

Tamsin did not look at him. "Neither is watching children lose sleep because a queue forgot to see them."

Lior almost dropped his notes.

Tamsin, who treated procedure like sacred architecture, had just stepped past it on purpose.

Judge Vale said, "Back to court. We conclude before noon."

As they turned to leave, Brindle stirred. His eyes opened halfway, cloudy but aware. He looked at Ashling and whispered, voice thin as thread:

"Did... did the story end yet?"

Ashling knelt beside the bed, tears bright but unshed.

"Not yet," they whispered back. "But we're getting there."

Chapter 8 — Arguments at the Edge of Mercy

Back in Sandglass Court, sunlight from the upper labyrinth filtered down through crystal shafts, turning the chamber air pale gold. The gallery was packed tighter than before. Word had spread.

Judge Vale struck the bench bell.

"Final arguments. Keep them precise."

Master Quill stood first. His voice held less steel now, more strain.

"Your Honor, evidence confirms two truths. One: institutional delay contributed to urgency. Two: the defendant knowingly broke core custodial law. If unauthorized extraction is excused whenever motive is sympathetic, trust collapses. Families must know bedtime minutes are protected."

He bowed his head briefly.

"I ask for conviction with structured clemency, not acquittal."

Then Ashling rose.

"I agree with half of that," they said. "Trust matters. Law matters. I do not ask to be declared innocent. I ask to be judged whole."

They faced the gallery.

"I harmed your nights. I did. Some children felt unsettled. Some caretakers were exhausted. I am sorry in ways larger than words."

One of the pajama-clad children in the back row leaned against her mother's shoulder, listening hard.

"I also spent every taken minute trying to keep my sibling from disappearing." Ashling swallowed. "I filed petitions. I waited. I ran out of waiting."

They turned back to the Judge.

"If punishment must come, let it repair. Let me return what can be returned. Let me stand in every wing and personally complete every bedtime story I clipped until families say enough."

Murmurs rose—surprised, thoughtful, uncertain.

Judge Vale looked to Tamsin. "Clerk analysis."

Tamsin stood with a slate board filled in tiny neat columns.

"Projected restitution model: thirty-seven unspent vials returned to communal reserve over six nights. For consumed minutes, equivalent restorative service possible through guided bedtime circles led by defendant and trained librarians over twelve weeks."

She turned a page.

"If participation remains voluntary and sessions are capped by wing capacity, children recover routine while receiving enhanced closure practices. Net sleep stabilization projected within nineteen nights."

Lior could practically see numbers dancing behind her glasses.

Judge Vale nodded. "And policy correction?"

"Immediate suspension of unlawful secondary review category. Emergency petitions from non-citizen narrative entities routed to primary triage, same as all urgent medical cases."

Master Quill bowed stiffly. "Registry accepts."

The Judge folded her hands.

"Before ruling, this court hears one final witness: apprentice observation."

Lior nearly swallowed his tongue. "Me?"

"You have copied every stage," Judge Vale said. "You are sworn. Speak only what you observed."

Lior rose on shaking legs.

"I observed harm," he said. "Families lost rest. That's true. I also observed records proving delayed petitions due to an unlawful policy. I observed treatment vials labeled and measured, not hidden for gain. I observed the defendant admitting facts even when denial might help."

He took a breath.

"I think the law was broken by a person and by a system. If we punish only one, the other keeps happening."

Silence held for a long three heartbeats.

Judge Vale's gaze softened, just barely.

"Noted."

She lifted the verdict sandglass from its cradle and turned it. Golden sand began to fall.

"This court recesses for deliberation. Return at final grain."

As people rose, the great pendulum swung overhead, marking out the waiting in solemn arcs. Lior sat back down, knees weak, and wondered what justice looked like when nobody walked away untouched.

Chapter 9 — The Fair Weight of Time

When the verdict bell rang, even the clocks seemed to listen.

Judge Vale entered in full bench robes, silver clockwork embroidery catching the light. She remained standing.

"In the matter of *The Labyrinth v. Ashling*, this court finds as follows."

She looked first to the gallery.

"Unauthorized extraction of protected bedtime minutes occurred. Harm occurred. Therefore, on the principal charge, the defendant is adjudged responsible."

A few nods. A few grim exhales.

The Judge then turned to Master Quill and the registry officers.

"This court also finds that an unlawfully inserted queue policy imposed discriminatory delay on urgent medical petitions for non-citizen narrative entities, materially contributing to the crisis."

Registry faces stiffened.

"Accordingly, accountability is shared."

Lior felt the room tilt toward attention.

"Sentence is restorative and supervisory, effective immediately."

Judge Vale raised one finger.

"First: all unspent extracted minutes are returned to communal reserve under healer and clerk oversight."

Second finger.

"Second: defendant Ashling will lead twelve weeks of voluntary bedtime restoration circles across affected wings, co-facilitated by librarians and family readers, to restore closure patterns and support children unsettled by clipped endings."

Third finger.

"Third: registry office enters six-month compliance watch. Unlawful policy is stricken. Emergency triage parity is mandatory. Clerk Tamsin is appointed independent timing auditor for the duration."

Tamsin's eyes widened behind her lenses.

Fourth finger.

"Fourth: compassionate care allocation for Brindle is approved today under supervised medical protocol."

A soft sound escaped Ashling, half sob, half laugh.

Judge Vale's voice gentled.

"No party is fully vindicated. No party is fully condemned. This is not tidy. It is fair."

She sat at last.

"Do you understand your obligations, Ashling?"

"I do," Ashling whispered.

"Do you accept them?"

"With gratitude."

Judge Vale nodded to the registry table.

"Do you, Master Quill?"

He bowed, shoulders heavy. "We do."

The Judge struck the bench bell once.

"So ordered."

For one heartbeat nobody moved. Then noise returned all at once: relieved tears, worried questions, cautious applause from a child who clearly hadn't checked if applause was allowed. Someone shushed, then laughed and stopped shushing.

Ashling turned toward the back benches where the pajama children sat.

"I owe you stories," they said.

A little boy with hair sticking up like a startled dandelion called out, "Long ones?"

Ashling's mouth twitched. "Very."

Lior watched Tamsin close her ledger, then open it again to a fresh page titled in meticulous script:

RESTORATION CIRCLES — WEEK 1

She caught Lior looking and handed him a stack of blank forms.

"Don't just stand there," she said, voice brisk but not unkind. "We've got twelve weeks to schedule."

For the first time in two nights, Lior smiled.

Justice, he thought, was not a gavel strike.

It was what happened after.

Chapter 10 — Twelve Nights of Mending

The first restoration circle gathered in the Moss Lantern Wing, where families sat on cushions shaped like mushrooms and foxes while tiny lights bobbed above like fireflies that had decided to stay indoors.

Ashling stood at the center with a stack of approved storybooks and a small brass timer Tamsin had calibrated to the second.

"Tonight," Ashling told the children, "we are practicing endings that help your hearts settle."

Lior sat near the back with attendance forms. Tamsin worked beside him, marking timing notes in tidy columns. Judge Vale attended quietly in plain robe, no bench insignia, just listening.

Ashling read slowly, voice rich as warm tea. When the final pages came, they did not rush. They lingered where comfort lived: the returned key, the mended blanket, the goodnight kiss, the final line that promised morning.

Children's shoulders dropped. One by one, yawns appeared.

By night three, something changed.

Parents who had arrived stiff with frustration began staying after to share old lullaby rhymes. Grandparents brought remembered endings from childhood villages. Older siblings volunteered to practice "soft-voice reading" with younger kids in side circles.

Restoration became communal.

Tamsin's data reflected it too.

"Average settling latency down by nineteen percent," she told Lior after week one.

"Settling what?"

"Time from story close to first calm breathing pattern." She shrugged at his expression. "I can count feelings when they have rhythm."

Week two brought Brindle, still fragile but brighter, wrapped in a teal shawl and holding Ashling's hand. The children eyed him curiously, then made room on the star rug without being asked.

During question time, a girl in striped pajamas raised her hand.

"Did you steal the minutes on purpose?"

The room held still.

Ashling knelt so they were eye level.

"Yes," they said. "I made a harmful choice because I was scared. Being scared explains it. It doesn't make it okay."

The girl considered this, then asked, "Are you still scary?"

Brindle answered before Ashling could.

"Only before breakfast," he said solemnly.

The room burst into giggles. Even Tamsin smiled into her ledger.

By week four, Lior noticed fewer tired faces at morning circles. By week six, households reported bedtime felt "whole again." By week eight, some families kept attending even after their own routines improved, simply because the shared storytelling had become beloved.

Not all was easy. A few caregivers remained angry. One walked out mid-session. Another wrote a sharp complaint about "court-sponsored sentimentality."

Judge Vale accepted every complaint and replied to each in writing, citing progress metrics and rights to opt out. Fairness, she told Lior, included making space for people not ready to forgive.

At week ten, Tamsin presented interim audit findings in open registry session, publicly striking three additional hidden delays she had uncovered in peripheral protocols.

"Systems drift," she said afterward, rubbing her eyes. "If no one checks clocks, they lie politely."

By week twelve, the circles no longer felt like sentence.

They felt like promise kept.

Chapter 11 — The Hearing of Completion

Completion hearing night arrived with rain tapping faintly through upper grates, a soft percussion above the chamber.

Sandglass Court filled again, though this time people carried less tension and more curiosity. Several children wore paper badges reading OFFICIAL ENDING EXPERT in crooked marker.

Tamsin called the case with formal precision.

"Review of restorative order compliance: The Labyrinth v. Ashling."

Judge Vale nodded. "Reports."

Master Quill rose first. "Registry confirms return of all unspent extracted minutes, implementation of triage parity, and compliance with independent audit directives. Petition processing times for urgent non-citizen cases reduced by sixty-eight percent."

He sounded like someone who had swallowed pride and discovered it was not fatal.

Tamsin followed.

"Clerk's report: twelve of twelve restoration cycles completed. Attendance exceeded projection by thirty-two percent. Bedtime stabilization metrics returned to baseline by cycle five and improved beyond baseline in four wings by cycle nine. Participant feedback: mostly positive, some critical, all logged."

She held up two thick binders.

"No unresolved restitution obligations remain."

Judge Vale turned to Ashling.

"Defendant report."

Ashling stood with Brindle beside them, hand in hand.

"I kept every session," Ashling said. "I listened to anger where it was offered, gratitude where it was offered, and silence where that was all people had. I do not ask this court to forget what I did. I ask only that you note I have done what you required."

Judge Vale considered them, then looked to the gallery.

"Any affected party wishing to speak may do so."

A father stood and said bedtime had become easier than before. A grandmother said she still felt bitter but appreciated the honesty. The striped-pajama girl announced, "Ashling does great dragon voices."

General agreement murmured through the benches.

Finally, Lior rose uncalled, then froze when everyone looked his way. Judge Vale gave a small nod to continue.

"I just want to place one observation in record," he said, voice shaking less than he expected. "In week one, people came to get back what was lost. By week twelve, many came to give something too. Endings, memory, patience."

He glanced toward Ashling and Brindle.

"I think we repaired more than minutes."

Judge Vale's gaze warmed.

"Entered."

She stood for final order.

"The court recognizes full completion of restorative sentence. Formal penalties are satisfied. Ashling's civic restrictions are lifted."

Ashling exhaled as if setting down a mountain.

"Further," Judge Vale continued, "this court issues Administrative Rule Forty-Two: urgent medical petitions from any sentient entity are to be triaged by need alone. Clerk Tamsin's audit office becomes permanent."

A pulse of surprise, then applause—real applause this time, unshushed.

Tamsin looked deeply uncomfortable and faintly proud.

Judge Vale struck the bell once, smiling despite herself.

"Case closed."

As people began to rise, Brindle tugged Ashling's sleeve.

"Can we go home now?"

Ashling knelt and pressed their forehead gently to his.

"Yes," they whispered. "This chapter can end."

Chapter 12 — The Story That Stayed

Weeks later, the labyrinth moved through summer toward harvest, and if you stood at the right cross-corridor around twilight, you could hear stories drifting from three wings at once.

Lior liked to stand there on his way to evening filing.

In Moss Lantern Wing, Ashling now led a weekly open circle by choice, not sentence. In the Atlas Wing, families borrowed "gentle ending kits" designed by librarians and tested by children with ruthless honesty. In Understack Infirmary, Brindle walked without flicker most days and had begun correcting doctors' grammar, which Healer Sera called "an excellent sign of recovery."

The court itself felt different too.

Tamsin's new audit desk occupied a corner where an old umbrella stand used to be. It now held policy maps pinned with red and green thread. She had trained two junior clerks and frightened six administrators into punctuality.

"Fear is efficient," she told Lior. Then, after a beat: "But clarity is kinder."

Judge Vale kept her calm, impossible balance, though Lior noticed she now asked one additional question in every complex case:

What pressure shaped this choice?

Not to excuse.

To understand.

One evening after closing, Lior found Ashling waiting by the pendulum stair with a wrapped parcel.

"For you," Ashling said.

Inside was a slim notebook bound in midnight-blue cloth. The first page read:

MARGINS WORTH KEEPING — notes on what laws forget, and how to help them remember.

Lior looked up, throat tight.

"I don't know enough to write this."

Ashling smiled. "You know enough to start."

That night, long after his official copying was done, Lior sat at a side table beneath the clocks and began.

He wrote about harm and repair. About rules and gaps. About how fairness was heavier than blame and lighter than vengeance. About one frightened story-spirit and one sick sibling and one clerk who could count feelings by

rhythm.

When he finished the first page, he carried the notebook to Tamsin for comment.

She adjusted her glasses, read in silence, and handed it back.

"Your comma placement is reckless," she said.

Lior groaned.

"But your premise is sound," she added. "Keep going."

Near midnight, the bronze bell sounded three times for a new hearing. Lior rose, gathered quills, and followed the familiar spiral down.

The Great Pendulum swung. The benches filled. Somewhere in the gallery, children in pajamas stifled giggles.

Judge Vale took her seat.

"This court now sits."

Lior opened a fresh page.

Above his first line he wrote the date, then, in smaller letters, one private reminder:

Every ending is someone's beginning.

And in homes all across the labyrinth, bedtime stories stretched to their proper close, five full minutes of gentle certainty returned, while listeners drifted toward sleep with the quiet confidence that endings, even hard-won endings, could still be kind.

THE END